The Rural Divide

A recent report that studied 1,362 underprivileged schoolchildren across 15 states confirmed something we had all suspected. The School Children's Online and Offline Survey (the SCHOOL survey), released in August 2021, established that poor children in rural India had suffered the most in terms of the disruption of their education during the pandemic. The school dropout rate in rural India was as high as 37 per cent in 2020–2021. The survey also found that 51 per cent of people in villages have access to a smartphone as compared to 77 per cent in urban areas, and the proportion of children regularly studying online is 15 per cent in villages and 31 per cent in cities.

As per the SCHOOL survey, only 8 per cent of the children were regularly studying via online classes in rural areas and 37 per cent were not studying at all. Among the primary causes was a lack of access to devices.

"The number of dropouts is as high as 50–60 per cent among those in classes IX and XI since they don't have a board exam to appear for," said Apratim Chatterjee, headmaster of Baksara High School in Howrah. "But even for class X and XII, the number of absentees was, on an average, 30 per cent. We couldn't blame the students. When we visited the homes of some of the dropouts, we saw that the home environment was just not conducive to studying. For example, they were living in cramped rooms inhabited by four to six family members. And though the family had a smartphone, it had to be shared with all other family members."

As per the 'Report on the Status of Education India 2020–21', a study by the firm Indian Researcher, "In the 6–10 age group, one out of every 20 students does not attend school. In secondary classes, it is one out of every 10 students". The survey was designed to see if the 'new normal' in the education system is creating a massive divide between the 'haves' and 'have-nots'. The well-off seem to be getting wealthier in terms of access to educational gadgets, database, learning apps, while the poor, denied such privileges, are getting poorer. As per a survey done by the NGO Child Fund India, 64 per cent children have expressed an intent to drop out if not provided additional educational support.

Take the case of Debkanta, a bright class XII student of Baksara High School, who suddenly stopped attending classes for the 2021–22 academic year, prompting his teachers to visit his home. They found that the pandemic had reduced Debkanta's father's earnings by half, forcing this promising student to take up a job as a mechanic at a repair service company for TVs, ACs and fridges. Debkanta was

is a place where, along with academic learning, children also develop skills such as empathy, friendships, imagination, respecting personal space, taking turns, listening to others as well as socially acceptable behaviour patterns," says Dr Sapna Bangar, psychiatrist and head, Mpower-The Centre, Mumbai. "You only had to attend an early or primary year online class during Covid to see teachers struggling to get children to follow instructions. What else could one expect from children who have never experienced school life and do not have a benchmark to fall back on?" Online education also restricts sensory learning to some extent and impacts the social-emotional development of students. "The need for social contact and connect is a basic human need, the lack of which is likely to lead to lop-sided personality development with poor social skills," says Karthik.

With both parents juggling work and household responsibilities during the lockdown, children very often were left to their own devices—phones, tablets and what have you. According to an OLX India survey in 2021, screen time for children in the 5-to-15-year age group shot up 100 per cent since the first lockdown and 84 per cent of the parents were worried about the increase in their children's screen time. And excessive screen time has been reported to be associated with psychological issues, low emotional stability, and greater risk of depression or anxiety. Kids also have access to smartphones from a very young age these days. A 2021 study by the National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR) found that kids as young as eight had their own personal smartphones, with only 10 per cent using them for learning and 60 per cent using them for chatting. In eight-year-old Madhav's (*name changed*) case, smartphone dependence wreaked havoc on his